

# Auction Checklist

*Bridge Habit Map*

## Habits

- ☐ Check vulnerability - use to determine aggression level in competitive auction
- ☐ Always bid to show new info - stop when no new info to show
- ☐ Use every bid to get positive and negative info — partner + opps → HCP + shape
- ☐ Start from minimum length & min HCP promised — refine as bids land
- ☐ Use opps' conventional bids to show their HCP / shape
- ☐ By end of auction — summarise what you know about opps + partner - HCP and shape
- ☐ Pick a tentative opening lead during the auction

## Strategy

- ☐ If it's our hand → bid our contract, or Dbl
- ☐ Watch for lead-directing double opportunities on artificial bids
- ☐ After you T/O and opps make a game try — don't push the bidding

- ☐ We have a fit AND opps have a fit + you have length or shortage in theirs → need fewer points for game (~20) in our suit
- ☐ When opps bid strangely, be careful

## Bids to remember

- ☐ You can reopen with a Dbl
- ☐ Bid of a minor after 4th-hand protection shows a weak 2 in that minor
- ☐ After our T/O Dbl: NT from responder tends to show a max hand
- ☐ After our T/O Dbl: a new suit or NT is strong
- ☐ After our Neg Dbl: a new suit is a weak 6-card suit
- ☐ Opps sacrifice → partner's Dbl is for penalties
- ☐ Opps sacrifice → Pass is a forcing pass (partner must Dbl or bid the suit again)
- ☐ Opps sacrifice → bidding the suit again shows the strongest hand

# Declarer Sheet — Notrump

*Bridge Habit Map*

## PLAN — DISCIPLINE & LEAD

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### Discipline

- ☐ Pause at least 10 seconds before playing from dummy
- ☐ Treat it as a play problem handed to you on paper
- ☐ Review the auction — what's bid, what's not
- ☐ Analyse the opening lead — length, honor, shortness?

### Pre-play evaluation

- ☐ Count points for us and the defenders
- ☐ Count our winners and losers
- ☐ Use info from opps' bidding and passing
- ☐ Use info from the opening lead
- ☐ Work out likely suit splits and where opps' high cards sit

### Design the play

- ☐ Tricks to create = contract – winners
- ☐ Tools: ruff in short hand, create shortage for a ruff, cross-ruff, finesse
- ☐ Look for loser-on-loser elimination, squeeze, or throw-in
- ☐ Confirm entries for the planned play
- ☐ Decide when and how to draw trumps

### Playing it out

- ☐ Don't be afraid to draw trumps even on a misfit
- ☐ If cross-ruffing, set up side suits first

- ☐ Play safe / the percentages — allow for 4-1 or 3-0 splits when a finesse is on
- ☐ If drawing trumps, make sure you have no suit losers in the short-trump hand
- ☐ Find losers in the long hand — discard them on dummy's winners
- ☐ In NT, if they lead your hidden 5-card suit, still play the hand properly
- ☐ If the outcome is fixed, try to fool the opps and sneak a trick

## PLAN — NOTRUMP

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### Count

- ☐ Count sure winners (off the top)
- ☐ Work out how many extra tricks needed

### Source of extras

- ☐ Pick suit(s) to develop — Force, Length, or Position
- ☐ Prefer Force when you can afford to lose the lead

### Hazards & control

- ☐ How many tricks can defenders cash when in?
- ☐ Identify the danger hand — who must you keep off lead?
- ☐ Plan hold-ups to sever defensive communication

### Execution

- ☐ Plan entries between hands; unblock high cards
- ☐ Decide which suit to attack first
- ☐ Cash short-suit winners last if needed as entries

# Declarer Sheet — Suit

*Bridge Habit Map*

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- ☐ Confirm entries for the planned play
- ☐ Decide when and how to draw trumps

### Playing it out

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- ☐ If cross-ruffing, set up side suits first
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## PLAN — SUIT

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### Count

- ☐ Count losers in each suit
- ☐ Pick a master hand (long-trump hand; stronger in 4-4)
- ☐ Cross-check by counting winners

### Source of extras

- ☐ Can dummy cover losers? (ruffs, side-suit, finesse, throw-in)
- ☐ Consider dummy reversal, cross-ruff, loser-on-loser, endplay

### Trump management

- ☐ Draw trumps now or postpone?
- ☐ If ruffs needed in dummy — set up before drawing
- ☐ Estimate trump leads needed; count opps' trumps as you go

### Hazards & control

- ☐ What will defenders attack when they get in?
- ☐ Identify the danger hand — keep them off lead

### Execution

- ☐ Plan entries between hands
- ☐ Decide order of attack across suits

# Defender Sheet

Bridge Habit Map

## DEFENSE PLAN

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### Discipline

- ☐ Don't rush, don't get rushed — especially trick 1
- ☐ Have a reason for what you do

### Count the points

- ☐ Add declarer + dummy HCP, subtract from 40
- ☐ Divide missing points using the auction
- ☐ If dummy is strong, give declarer minimum for their bid

### Picture the unseen hands

- ☐ Build a hand-pattern for declarer (e.g. 3-5-3-2)
- ☐ Memorise your hand + dummy before playing

### Count declarer's tricks

- ☐ Count declarer's distribution, HCP, and tricks
- ☐ No side-suit tricks for you? Look to trump (overruff, uppercut, promotion)

### Identify the winning defense

- ☐ Which 2–3 declarer hand-patterns let you beat the contract?
- ☐ What suit does declarer fear?

### Active or passive (binary)

- ☐ Long-suit declarer with a source of tricks → ACTIVE
- ☐ Balanced declarer, no obvious source → PASSIVE (don't break suits)
- ☐ Don't grab aces prematurely — aces capture kings

### Opening lead (if on lead)

- ☐ Determine if lead should be passive or aggressive
- ☐ Avoid suits opponents bid; favour unbid suits
- ☐ vs NT: 4th best from longest, or top of sequence

- ☐ vs suit: K from AK, top of doubleton; don't underlead an ace
- ☐ Trump lead if auction suggests a cross-ruff; not vs misfit
- ☐ Lead partner's bid suit unless you have a clear reason not to

### Watch & remember

- ☐ Commit the first few cards from partner + declarer to memory
- ☐ Decide now which spot cards in which suits will matter

### Defensive evaluation

- ☐ REAP — Zia update
- ☐ In competitive auctions, weigh partner's bids — especially the no-bids
- ☐ At trick 1, fix declarer's and partner's points and shape

### Defensive play

- ☐ Changing suit: high discourages, low encourages the same-suit return
- ☐ Partner's discouraging opening lead → think about where his values are

### Leads

- ☐ Lead a trump if opps are playing in their second suit (cut dummy's ruffs)
- ☐ Lead the ace of our suit if you have it — don't underlead it
- ☐ Don't lead trumps on a misfit unless it reduces ruffing

### Signals & declarer set-ups

- ☐ Give and look for all defensive signals
- ☐ When signalling, don't make dummy's cards high
- ☐ Don't make dummy high or give declarer discards — if you must, take your tricks
- ☐ Careful cashing winners at the end unless you know you won't set up declarer
- ☐ Always reduce dummy's trumps if a short-suit ruff is possible